Newsletter

MAERSK

FLEET MANAGEMENT & TECHNOLOGY

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Technical, Safety & Systems

LevLash and the next generation in cargo stowage

Organisation & Collaboration

Mental Health Green Ribbon campaign

Vessels, People & Events

Maersk Brani – Rescue of Yachtsman from North East Atlantic Ocean – A Personal Account

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Front page: "A Gaze Beyond Horizon" photo by D/C Aldrin Ulep has won the Highly Commended Photo in the ITF Photo Contest

Little Steps for my Cosmic Dreams

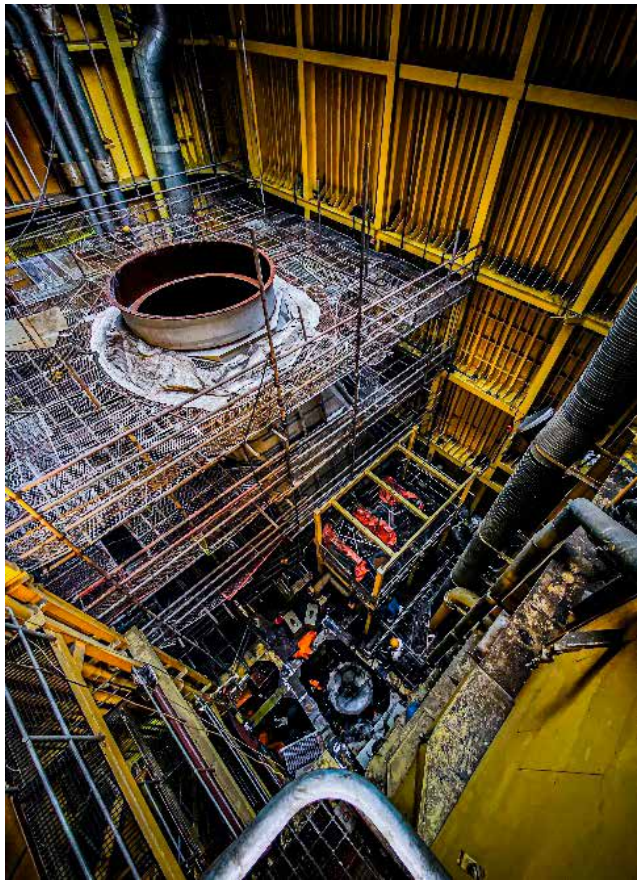
BY D/C ALDRIN ULEP

***'When you want something, the universe conspires in helping you to achieve it'* — these words from Coelho* have been a stronghold throughout the intentional years of my existence. I hope I can bring justice to these stories and inspire through my writing and perspective in photography.**

I was raised in a striving family in Cagayan, Philippines. My parents both lost their father at an early age. They never graduated from college, nor had my mother entered high school. My father took care of his inherited farmlands and later married my mother. I grew up observing how they struggled to finance our education. My father worked day and night in the fields to send my three sisters to college and my two brothers to high school and grade school. Being the youngest, I felt so much love and importance in seeing the efforts of my family to uplift our condition that I felt a supernova exploded inside me.

'*That's one small step for man and one big leap for mankind.*' - I wonder how Neil Armstrong** and Buzz Aldrin** felt accomplishing one of the greatest visions of humanity, and the pride and inspiration my father felt when I came to the world three decades after. Born on the second day of January 1999, I was named after the second man who stepped on the surface of the moon, Aldrin.

I was a persistent achiever and a leader since grade school. I was in the third year of high school when my father left us, for good. I felt so irrelevant, but my father has always taught me to trust in Him and all His plans for me. And I did. I finished high school as the Class Valedictorian and with perseverance, I made my father proud when I entered the University of the Philippines and took up a bachelor's degree in Industrial Engineering. Studying at the countries' most prestigious University was tough. I failed several courses during my first semester, but I didn't give up. I propelled myself through the hard times by keeping my father's advice - to keep my persistence and my positive mindset.



"Funnel Scrubber" – the photo above, taken by D/C Aldrin Ulep recently won 2nd Prize on the Maritime Industry Authority (MARINA) Seafarer's Photo Contest with the theme, "New Technologies for Greener Shipping", during the Philippines' s23rd National Maritime Week (3rd week of September 2022)

In 2017, a great opportunity came. I transferred to the Maritime Academy of Asia and the Pacific to keep our family financially stable. I was sponsored by Maersk and I couldn't be happier, as it was a dream to work for them even when I was still in the University. With all the odds, I became a midshipman and finished my first semester in the Academy with my name on top of the President's List. Days before I came back home, an unforeseen plot twist happened, and it shattered my soul to pieces. My beloved mother left us as well. I never thought that there's a darker place than our universe. I looked up, saw the stars and the moon. See, no matter how dark the universe is, there are billions of stars and planets shining, a billion reasons to continue believing that you can make it if you aim for it.

I had to carry on for my family and fulfill my parents' longing for my success. Life at the Academy, looking back, proved to be rather exciting. It's crazy how time can change our feelings about things. Back then, the day-to-day life there was fast, habitual, and physically challenging. I was the Academic Officer of my Class which allowed me to share my knowledge and help my classmates and underclassmen steer their courses steadily. I also joined the Academy's Platoon Rifle Drill Team to fully immerse myself in the process and expand my experiences. It is also there that I continued to develop my passion for writing and photography as a contributor to the Campus Publication – 'Kamaya

Point' and became an active member of the debate team.

Then, in 2019, I was chosen as one of the Ten Outstanding Maritime Students of the Philippines for my contributions to my Academy and the seafaring community around it. I found myself in a place where I was able to uplift people and share opportunities to aspiring seafarers. This achievement relies on influencing the people around me to be the best version of themselves and together reaching heights we never thought we were capable of. Earlier this year, I finally graduated from the Maritime Academy of Asia and the Pacific with an Exemplary Award. The end of a journey commences the beginning of a new one. Now, out in the world comes more daring challenges - but also unending possibilities to become victorious. I resorted back to my pen and camera.

My fondness for writing and photography has always been driven by their ability to show different points of view in life. You can create something only you can express, and think about something only you can make sense of. It's the power to empower the less fortunate and the unspoken heroes of our generation that prompts me to always look and create something never read or seen before. My dream is to share stories of the hope, strength, and persistence of my colleagues, friends, and my brothers and sisters at sea— extraordinary people whose impact makes our world a better place.



Above: In the last Crew Connect 2022, D/C Aldrin Ulep received his award for the photo Contest of ITF. He was joined on stage with Dennis Hansen, Ashish Mediratta and Prashanth Nath Sharma

Mostly seen on deck and engine duties, the journey of a seafarer is a relentless battle. My entire sailing career has been plagued by the pandemic and for me, there was a lot to look forward to.

Veteran seafarers on the other hand, had to adapt and be vigilant on their solutions to bridge the status quo from the norm, and it was a sight to see. As if the world was telling me that I had to capture the moment, from videoke sessions, film showings, Saturday barbecues to Zumba sessions, Sports Tournaments, and team exercise sessions. We fill our voids with these little cheerful moments we find ourselves in, untroubled by the uncertainty of tomorrow and away from the yearning fire for our loved ones — separated by the seven seas and yet bonded by stars above. The sea is overflowing with hope, a reminder to the world that even in the most isolated place in the midst of a pandemic, we can find something to be grateful for, first with the people around us.

I would like to thank the International Transport Workers' Federation (ITF) Seafarers' Trust for allowing me to put my interest in writing and photography in a good cause. I was able to feature the life of seafarers onboard during the pandemic through their platform, winning two photos in their 40th Aniverssary Portraits Photography Competition 2021 (Out of Sight, not Out of Mind) and had my poem recited on stage at the Crew Connect Global Awards 2022 held in Manila, where one of my photos also cited as Highly Commended in their 2022 Photography Competition (Life at Sea). I also won 3rd Prize at the Sea Health and Welfare's Seafaring Photography Competition 2021 (Denmark) and 2nd Prize in Maritime Industry Authority Photography Competition 2022 (Philippines). It is with such opportunities as these that I am both humbled and proud to be able to glorify the sacrificial life of seafarers around the world.

The circumstances during the pandemic gave me the opportunity to showcase the unwavering dedication of my colleagues, by giving them little photo-shoots to celebrate their unparalleled effort to keep the world and the industry afloat. It underlines an important skill I harness throughout my seafaring life, being empathetic — an act of attempting to understand other

people's emotion, perspective, or their reality. As far as I know, the success of a working environment in achieving its goal depends on the ability of every single individual to deal with his or her colleague. It taught me to treat people with kindness and humility.

I am honored and privileged to be a part of a Family that takes good care of its people. Both of my ships as a Cadet (Emma Maersk, Monte Cervantes) had a wonderful and supportive crew holding on with the company's core values of constant care. I was treated respectfully and professionally despite being least experienced. Maersk has paved the way for my dreams coming to a reality and I will be forever thankful for it.

I would also like to thank my Academy, the Maritime Academy of Asia and the Pacific (MAAP) and the Associated Marine Officers' and Seamen's Union of the Philippines (AMOSUP) for developing me to become a competent seafarer and providing the means to conquer the seven seas. As I embark on this journey, I will continue to devote myself to this profession, and strive for excellence.

Life is a roller-coaster ride. At first, you become afraid of something fun (forward looking) and then you start getting along with the ride, enjoying every moment. Setbacks can be turned into a step forward with a winning mindset. Falling isn't failing when you learn to get up stronger to conquer greater fear. Fall forward, hold on to your dreams and don't let the moment devour the might inside you. You're the master of your destiny, create something beautiful of it. Take that one small step, because otherwise you'll never know what the universe has for you.

**) Paulo Coelho de Souza is a Brazilian lyricist and novelist and a member of the Brazilian Academy of Letters since 2002. His novel The Alchemist became an international best-seller, and he has published 28 more books since then.*

***) Commander Neil Armstrong and lunar module pilot Buzz Aldrin became the first people to walk on the moon when they landed the Apollo Lunar Module Eagle on its surface in July 1969*



Night watch at port monitoring cargo operations. Taken by D/C Aldrin Ulep.

Lost Integers

BY D/C ALDRIN ULEP

My First ship,
As my Second home,
On my Third month,
In Four countries,
and Five hours of sleep.
Six mooring operations,
Seventh cargo watches.
Eight ports,
Nine voyages,
and Ten thousand miles at sea...
The Sun rises and sets,
Then the moon ascends.
One day, one dream,
The universe conspiring.
Twenty five mentors,
Thirty two headings,
and Fifty knots of winds;
Full Speed Ahead,
Steaming and steering,
Rolling or Pitching,
Around the world, goods we bring.



'Lost Integers' photo by D/C Alrin Ulep

Ninety nine revolutions a minute
And Hundred ton of fuel a day.
If Out of sight we sail
On minds we hope to stay.
One Hundred twelve and a half red and green,
One Hundred thirty five white on stern,
May our lumens continuously shine brighter.
For over 180 days at sea,
Life will never be easy,
And if counting twistlock makes you dizzy,
Estimation is the key.
For if there is one thing it reminds me,
That is no matter how much it can be,
Spend hours counting tirelessly,
The Sun sets, and the day ends.
And if ever you forget,
There should be no regret
You will still have me,
Counting with you endlessly.